EUROPE BETWEEN THE WARS

AFTER THE END of hostilities with Germany in 1918, the British and French toyed with intervention in Russia against the Bolshevik regime, then engaged in conflicts on its western borders. The commitment of naval forces in the Baltic and the Black Sea brought little positive result besides a demonstration of British fighting spirit in a raid on Kronstadt. A mutiny aboard the French battleships *Jean Bart* and *France* in the Black Sea in April 1919 hastened disillusionment with interventionism and pressure to demobilize. No further naval conflict occurred in Europe until 1936, when right-wing Nationalist officers in Spain rebelled against the left-wing government of the Republic. Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy gave the Nationalists military support while the Soviet Union backed the Republic, and Britain and France operated a "non-intervention" policy. The Spanish navy split like the rest of the country and elements of it fought one another. Aided by Germany and Italy, which deployed submarines to attack Republican convoys, the Nationalists had the better of the naval war, although this was marginal to their eventual victory in 1939.

RUSSIAN CIVIL WAR

RAID ON KRONSTADT



Date August 18, 1919
Forces British: 1 carrier, 8 coastal motor boats; Russians: 1 dreadnought, 1 pre-dreadnought, and many other vessels
Losses: British: 3 coastal motor boats; Russians: 1 dreadnought, 1 pre-dreadnought, 1 depot ship

Location Kronstadt, Baltic

The British navy developed Coastal Motor Boats (CMBs) during World War I, small torpedo craft designed to attack warships in harbor. After the war Lieutenant Augustus Agar was sent to the Baltic with two CMBs to help the British secret service destabilize the revolutionary Bolshevik government in Russia. Agar made a night raid on the Russian naval base at Kronstadt on June 17, 1919, sinking the cruiser *Oleg*.

Rear Admiral Sir Walter Cowan was commanding a Royal Navy force in the Baltic blockading the Russian navy in Kronstadt. Inspired by Agar's example, he had a flotilla of CMBs brought from Britain. Led by Commander Claude Dobson, they attacked Kronstadt on the night of August 18-19, supported by aircraft from the carrier *Vindictive*. Dobson led the first wave of four boats into the harbor. His CMB 31 torpedoed the pre-dreadnought *Andrei Pervozvanny*. CMB 88 had her captain killed but Sub-Lieutenant Gordon Steele, taking control under heavy fire, torpedoed the dreadnought battleship *Petropavlovsk*. A second wave of CMBs faced intensifying Russian resistance. Two boats collided in the dark and another was cut in two by a shell. Both Steele and Dobson were awarded Victoria Crosses for their part in the raid.



Depot ship sunk
The British motor boats attacking Kronstadt sank the submarine depot ship *Pamyat Azova* as well as dreadnought and pre-dreadnought battleships.

SPANISH CIVIL WAR

CAPE ESPARTEL



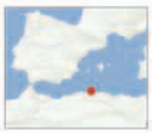
Date September 29, 1936
Forces Republicans: 3 destroyers; Nationalists: 2 cruisers
Losses Republicans: 1 destroyer; Nationalists: none

Location Straits of Gibraltar

At the start of the Spanish Civil War Republican sailors took control of many naval vessels and blocked the movement of Nationalist troops by sea from Spanish Morocco to southern Spain. At the Atlantic port of El Ferrol Nationalists won control of warships including the light cruiser *Almirante Cervera* and heavy cruiser *Canarias*. Under Captain Francisco Moreno, the two ships sailed to the Straits of Gibraltar and attacked a Republican flotilla. *Almirante Ferrandiz* was sunk and another destroyer, *Gravina*, severely damaged. The rest fled for safety, leaving the sea route between North Africa and Spain open for Nationalist forces.

SPANISH CIVIL WAR

CAPE CHERCHELL



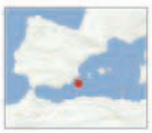
Date September 7, 1937
Forces Republicans: 2 light cruisers, 4 destroyers; Nationalists: 1 heavy cruiser
Losses Republicans: none; Nationalists: none

Location Off Cape Cherchell, Algeria

The Nationalist heavy cruiser *Baleares* intercepted a Republican convoy of four supply ships escorted by the light cruisers *Libertad* and *Mendez Nuñez* and four destroyers. Although outnumbered, *Baleares* engaged the Republican cruisers. *Libertad* scored a hit that damaged *Baleares*'s electronics, temporarily disabling her guns. The Republican cruisers took the opportunity to steam after the convoy, but they were later caught again by *Baleares*, pursuing with her electronics repaired. Suffering further damage, the Nationalist cruiser broke off the engagement and, joined by the cruiser *Canarias*, sailed back to port at Malaga.

SPANISH CIVIL WAR

CAPE PALOS



Date March 5–6, 1938
Forces Republicans: 2 light cruisers, 5 destroyers; Nationalists: 2 heavy cruisers, 1 light cruiser
Losses Republicans: none: Nationalists: 2 heavy cruisers, 1 light cruiser

Location Off Cartagena, Spain

On the night of March 5-6, 1938, the cruisers *Baleares*, *Canarias*, and *Almirante Cervera*, under the command of Rear Admiral Manuel de Vierna, were escorting two Italian freighters to Nationalist Spain. At the same time a Republican force of cruisers and destroyers under Vice Admiral Luis de Ubieta left the port of Cartagena, intending to raid the Nationalist harbor at Palma on Mallorca.

Just after midnight the two naval forces ran into one another. The Republicans fruitlessly fired a number of torpedoes before the Nationalist cruisers disappeared into the darkness. Around 2:15 a.m. the two forces met again. Neither side was capable of effective gun-aiming at night but the Nationalist cruiser *Baleares* made the mistake of opening fire and the gun flashes provided a target for the Republican destroyers to aim for. Three destroyers fired a total of 12 torpedoes, two of which struck *Baleares*, blowing up the forward magazine and the bridge. Admiral Manuel de Vierna was among those killed.

Blazing from stem to stern, *Baleares* was almost run into by her fellow cruiser *Canarias*, following directly behind. *Canarias* and *Almirante Cervera* quit the scene, leaving *Baleares* to her fate. Fortunately there were two British destroyers in the area that rescued more than half of the sinking cruiser's 765 crew. The Republican ships meanwhile returned to port at Cartagena, allowing *Canarias* and *Almirante Cervera* to return at dawn to collect the survivors, transferring them to the Nationalist cruisers under Republican air attack. The battle of Cape Palos was a Republican success but had no strategic consequences.



Attack on Cartagena
Spanish Nationalists bomb the Republican naval base at Cartagena near Cape Palos. The battle of Cape Palos in 1938 was the last Republican victory in a war that the Republic was losing.